

BHASKAR PAUL



Off-Shoulder Redux

A huge trend on the international runways, the shoulder of the 80s was seen again at the Lakme Fashion Week. Designers like Anand Kabra (L) and Arjun Saluja kept the drama relegated to the shoulders. Kabra's silver plating over black ensembles caught the eye as did Saluja's structured shoulders.

yet don't come at the cost of a Nano. If Nachiket Barve focused on richer colours and let the surface texturing add the drama, Anand Kabra focused on his sharp silhouette with attention to shoulders. Kabra's saris didn't load up on the traditional sequins and zari. Instead the opulence was created through circular patterns.

Reinvention wasn't relegated to design. Mark-ups on designer apparel, often considered unreasonable even without the gloom and doom of this year, are down by almost 30 per cent. Customers who used to buy a dress for Rs 10,000 are now buying two for Rs 5,000. This is exactly why sensitive pricing makes sense. Even established designers like Sabyasachi Mukherjee's line this time started at Rs 3,500. But even though designers are going that extra mile to balance creativity



A-line is Topline

Volume is out and slimmer cuts are back. "People want multi-purpose dresses they can wear or team them with a churidar and dupatta for formal evenings," says designer Anupama Dayal (L).

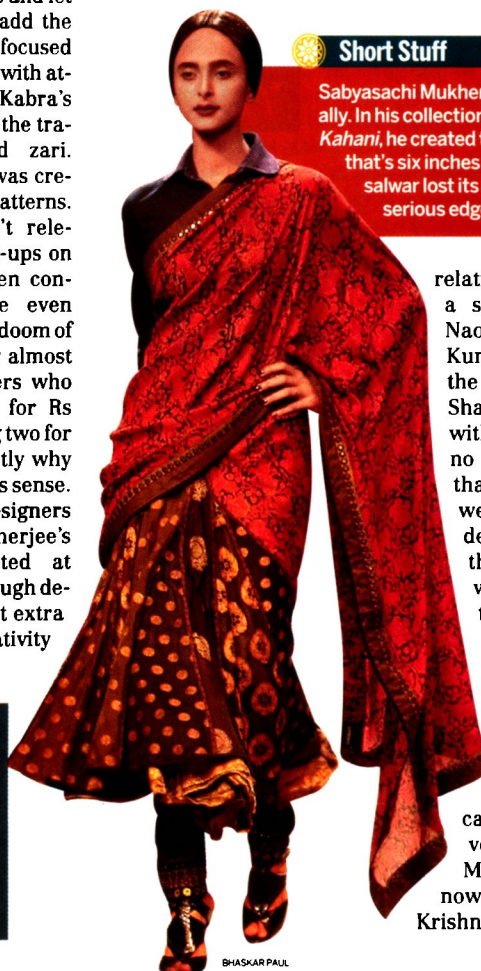
with commerce, not everyone was happy with how things proceeded at the fashion week. At a new location in the suburbs, after its long run at the National Centre for Performing Arts, the fashion event was geographically closer to Bollywood than ever before. And that's probably why every day was more about who walked the ramp rather than which designer showed what. Designers, unsure of their designs, tripped over each other to grab a showstopper. From Minnisha Lamba to Genelia D'Souza to Shweta

Bharadwaj, who can boast of just five minutes in a film, walked the ramp.

Always promoted as a premiere trade event, the rumours doing the rounds in the designer fraternity were that this fashion week had lost its focus. "What's the point of getting all the media hype if the designers don't sell?" asks a designer. International buyers were largely missing this year and the ones that did arrive weren't exactly treated like royalty. Front row seats, traditionally reserved for buyers, were given to friends and

Short Stuff

Sabyasachi Mukherjee (L) cut it short, literally. In his collection, *Neela aur Bagardandi ki Kahani*, he created the *chhotu sari*, or the sari that's six inches shorter. The traditional salwar lost its length but gained some serious edge by ending at the knee.



relatives of stars. Add to this a show co-organised by Naomi Campbell, Akshay Kumar unbuttoning on the ramp and a *dhoti*-clad Shah Rukh Khan strutting with a golden sling and no one even remembered that this was fashion week. Some optimistic designers were excited that the tough times were making them push their creativity, while others were happy that the unnecessary bling that had drowned all else, was beating a retreat. "Historically whenever there's a calamity, fashion reinvents and becomes edgy. Maybe that will happen now," says designer Krishna Mehta. Maybe. ■